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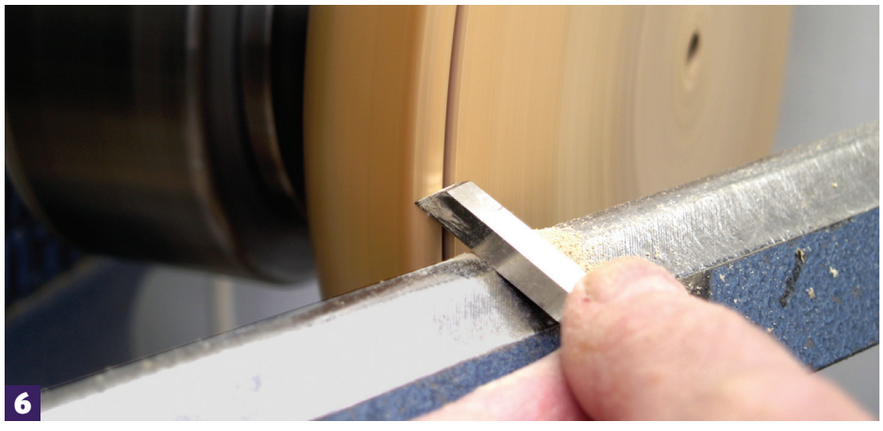
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Shaping the underside

2 As this is a reasonably thick piece of beech you can afford to cut the spigot directly into the blank. Having removed the waste wood with the bowl gouge, the spigot is converted into a dovetail using the long point of the skew to form the angle

3 I like to make the foot of a bowl about a third of the overall diameter. Mark out an approximately 75mm circle and use a 6mm bead forming tool to cut a neat round bead into the blank. I used an Ashley Iles bead forming tool, which I find very useful for forming beads simply and accurately. Working carefully, remove the waste outside the bead, down to the level of the bottom of the bead

4 Bearing in mind that the opposite face of the blank has yet to be trued up and making an allowance for this, mark a line on the edge of the blank to represent the bowl's maximum diameter. Then use the bowl gouge to shape the bowl in a smooth curve from the foot to this pencil line

5 This piece is very nicely spalted – good black lines and some colour variation but with no soft or 'punky' regions to cause problems. Sand the surface from 120 grit through to 400 grit before sealing and polishing with beeswax and carnauba wax. There are conflicting opinions, and the jury is still out, on whether the fungal spores released by sanding spalted wood are dangerous or not. Why risk it? Wear a good quality mask to avoid breathing the dust

Hollowing out

6 Now reverse the bowl, holding the dovetail spigot in the four-jaw chuck. After truing up with the bowl gouge, the top face is angled down towards the pencil line marked on the edge. Stopping about 3mm or so above this line, use the 6mm bead forming tool to form the edge bead of the bowl

7 Use a smaller 6mm bowl gouge with a swept-back grind to shape the rim in a gentle curve down to the bottom of the bead. Note the bevel is in contact with the wood and the flute is pointing to about 10 o'clock. Cut slightly to the left of the tip. Sand the bead and the rim to 400 grit before continuing. This is the time when the rim has its maximum support and I always think it best to finish as much work as possible on it at this stage

8 When starting a hollowing cut with a bowl gouge, encourage it to go where you want by making a starting groove with the long point of a skew chisel. Make a few preliminary hollowing cuts with the 13mm bowl gouge. Now we tackle the large undercut. Note there is still a considerable amount of wood in the centre of the bowl to give it rigidity while you are working near the edge

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